

Class 10th | English



First Flight

TREES- L1

The Trees

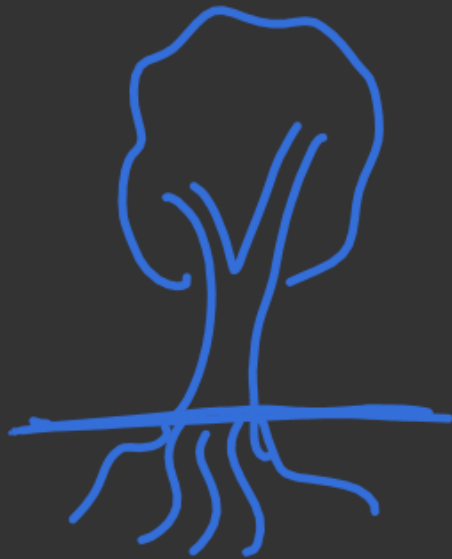
Can there be a forest without trees? Where are the trees in this poem, and where do they go?

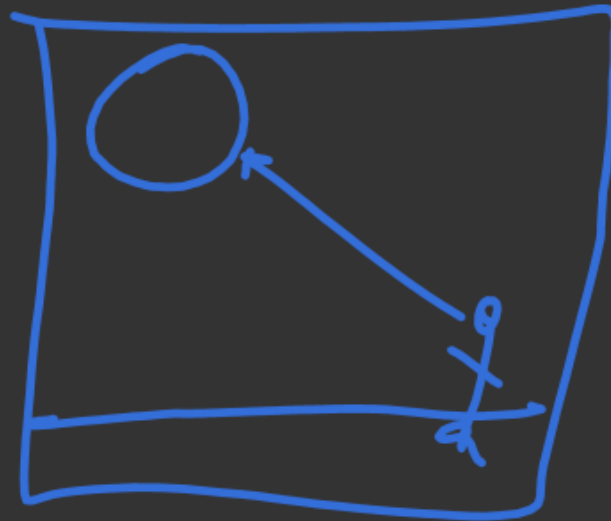
The trees inside are moving out into the forest,
the forest that was empty all these days
where no bird could sit
no insect hide
no sun bury its feet in shadow
the forest that was empty all these nights
will be full of trees by morning.

All night the roots work
to disengage themselves from the cracks
in the veranda floor.
The leaves strain toward the glass
small twigs stiff with exertion
long-cramped boughs shuffling under the roof
like newly discharged patients
half-dazed, moving
to the clinic doors.

I sit inside, doors open to the veranda
writing long letters
in which I scarcely mention the departure
of the forest from the house.

The night is fresh, the whole moon shines
in a sky still open
the smell of leaves and lichen
still reaches like a voice into the rooms.





Reached
the
Forest

My head is full of whispers
which tomorrow will be silent.
Listen. The glass is breaking.
The trees are stumbling forward
into the night. Winds rush to meet them.
The moon is broken like a mirror,
its pieces flash now in the crown
of the tallest oak.

ADRIENNE RICH

Adrienne Rich was born in Baltimore, Maryland, U.S.A. in 1929. She is the author of nearly twenty volumes of poetry, and has been called a feminist and a radical poet.

First Flight

Glossary

to disengage themselves: to separate themselves

strain: make efforts to move

bough: branch

shuffling: moving repeatedly from one position to another

lichen: crusty patches or bushy growth on tree trunks/bare ground formed by association of fungus and alga.

Thinking about the Poem

- Find, in the first stanza, three things that cannot happen in a treeless forest.
 - What picture do these words create in your mind: "... sun bury its feet in shadow..."? What could the poet mean by the sun's 'feet'?
- Where are the trees in the poem? What do their roots, their leaves, and their twigs do?
 - What does the poet compare their branches to?
- How does the poet describe the moon: (a) at the beginning of the third stanza, and (b) at its end? What causes this change?
 - What happens to the house when the trees move out of it?
 - Why do you think the poet does not mention "the departure of the forest from the house" in her letters? (Could it be that we are often silent about important happenings that are so unexpected that they embarrass us? Think about this again when you answer the next set of questions.)

THEME

- The theme is conflict between man and nature.
- With the growth and development of society, human beings have used nature for their own benefit and caused a lot of harm to it.
- In order to use natural resources like forests, minerals etc. men have forgotten the importance of nature.
- The presence of a few trees inside our homes does not become equal to nature, it is a very false idea of nature.
- Real nature is outside, in the forests that we have destroyed.

POETIC DEVICES

- Rhyme scheme: There is no rhyme scheme in the poem. It's written in 'free verse'
- Imagery- The poem floats and moves through or imagination
- Simile- Like newly discharged patients./Still reaches like a voice into the rooms./The moon is broken like a mirror.
- Personification: The trees inside are moving out into the forest./ No sun bury its feet in shadow.
- Symbolism: The poet uses 'the trees' to connote the significance of forests and raise the issue of 'deforestation' → condition of women
- Alliteration: long letters, leaves and lichen
- Anaphora: the repetition of the word "the" in the first two lines.
- Metaphor: 'trees' metaphorically to represent helplessness of woman in the patriarchal society.
- Enjambment: the forest that was empty all these days...empty all these nights

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Thank You



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